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Teacher Identity and Professional Portfolio Final Reflection

Throughout this course, I have learned a lot about myself, teaching methodology, and the kind of teacher I want to work towards becoming. I was stuck by how much concrete and systematised methodology exists surrounding the development and delivery of learning experiences and how directly I could trace back my most influential teachers and lessons to its application. I discovered how important it is to me that students experience success in my class and the ways in which that success can be facilitated and recognized. The excitement and motivation that comes with brainstorming creative implementations of curriculum surprised me as a person who tends towards direct and logical thinking and gives me something with which to continue developing my comfort and capability. Most of all, learning more about the craft of teaching and the direct, tangible results that can be achieved using best practices solidified my drive to continue learning and growing to become the best teacher that I can be.

Given my own experiences with the education system, I had assumed for a while that the lecture-and-textbook method – direct instruction – was the best or really only way to get students to any level of proficiency in subjects like math. I had had some fantastic teachers who did their best to give one-on-one support when it was needed, but in some ways it seemed that students reached a point where they understood or didn't. Reading and hearing about all of the different instructional methods and how effective a mixed-methodology approach is in bridging the gap for students with different preferred ways of learning, I realized the extent to which teachers can adapt their lessons to fit the needs of the class rather than the other way around and how much more there was to learn about the science and art of teaching.

The importance of high expectations to students' experiences in the classroom made me rethink how I want to appear as a teacher; understanding the immense pressure that adolescents face at school, but ensuring that I communicate to each student that I consider them fully capable of achieving whatever goals they have. I want to always be able to look

past what struggles a student is having in the moment and through to the bigger picture of their strengths, experiences, and needs.

The creativity inherent to teaching was something that I had assumed that I would struggle with as an emerging teacher, but practicing brainstorming and fleshing out lesson plans, learning the process of backwards design and imagining some of the ways I can reshape experiences to suit different audiences, I found that I really enjoyed it. In a way, I had been seeing creativity and problem solving as two entirely distinct skills, lacking the one and excelling in the other. This course has taught me that, at least in teaching, there is more of an overlap than I had anticipated and that by building out a toolbox of resources and methods I can respond to challenges with novel solutions.

One thing in particular that I will have to work on to become a more effective teacher is the willingness to admit what I do not know and openness surrounding my mistakes. I want to model those virtues for my students, but seeming wrong or anything but perfectly prepared feels uncomfortable still. I am working on reframing how I view the learning process for myself as well as my students: less competitive and more collaborative, less individual and more communal, less hierarchical and more of a shared experience.

The most important thing I will be taking away from this course is just how much of a breadth and depth there is to everything that goes into being a teacher and the newfound desire I have to explore as much of it as I can. The view of teaching as a skill to master, but whose mastery is never fully complete and how I can use that as a motivation to be constantly reflecting on and improving my teaching practice is something that I hope I will be able to keep central to my journey going forward.